A Report on Chinese College Students' Spending Habits

Introduction

In recent years, stories about college students falling into debt due to overspending and misuse of credit have become increasingly common. Some students rely heavily on online lending platforms, while others exhaust their monthly allowance within the first week. These financial problems not only cause stress but also distract students from their academic work. To better understand this issue, we conducted a survey on Chinese college students' spending habits.

Methodology

We designed a questionnaire containing both multiple-choice and open-ended questions covering five key areas: how students spend their pocket money, why they sometimes face financial distress, how they solve financial problems, whom they turn to for help, and how they can maintain financial health. We then interviewed six students on campus, including two freshmen, two sophomores, one junior, and one senior, to collect diverse perspectives. The findings were shared and analyzed within our group.

Findings

How Students Spend Their Money

The survey reveals that the three largest spending categories for college students are food and snacks (including bubble tea and takeout), online shopping (clothing, cosmetics, and gadgets), and social activities (dining out, karaoke, and movies). On average, students spend about 1,500 to 2,000 yuan per month. Notably, three out of six interviewees admitted that they spend more than half of their allowance on food and drinks alone.

> *"I order takeout almost every meal because it's convenient, and I never cook,"* said one senior.

Why Students Get into Financial Distress

The main reasons students face financial trouble are impulsive online shopping and lack of budgeting skills. Four interviewees said they often buy things on sale even when they don't need them, especially during promotions like Double 11. Two freshmen mentioned that they had never managed money independently before coming to college.

> *"I used to get 50 yuan a day from my parents for food, but now I get 1,500 yuan a month all at once. I had no idea how to plan, so I ran out of money by the 15th,"* said one freshman.

Additionally, peer pressure plays a role—two students admitted they spend more when going out with friends because they don't want to look cheap.

How Students Solve Financial Problems

When facing financial shortages, students adopt different strategies. The most common solution is asking parents for extra money (4 out of 6). Two students said they take part-time jobs such as tutoring or working at a café. One junior mentioned using a budgeting app to track daily expenses, which helped him cut unnecessary spending by 30%. However, one freshman admitted to briefly using an online lending app to cover a shortfall, though he paid it back quickly after realizing the high interest rates.

From Whom Students Seek Help

Most students turn to their parents when they need financial help or advice. Only two interviewees said they discuss money matters with friends. Surprisingly, none of the six students had ever sought help from school counselors or financial education programs.

> *"I didn't even know the university offers courses on personal finance,"* one student said.

How Students Can Stay Financially Healthy

Students who manage their money well shared several useful habits: making a monthly budget and sticking to it, cooking instead of ordering takeout, using the 50/30/20 rule (50% for necessities, 30% for wants, 20% for savings), and avoiding shopping apps during sales events.

> "*I transfer 300 yuan there every month. I don't touch it unless it's an emergency,*" *the senior interviewee recommended, suggesting setting up a separate savings account.*

Analysis

The survey findings point to several important conclusions. First, most Chinese college students lack basic financial literacy. Having managed by their parents throughout high school, they are suddenly given full control of a monthly budget but have no idea how to plan. This transition shock is especially severe for freshmen.

Second, the digital economy makes overspending dangerously easy. With one click on a phone, students can order takeout, buy clothes on credit, or even borrow money from online platforms. The convenience of mobile payment makes spending feel abstract—you don't see cash leaving your wallet, so you don't feel the loss.

Third, peer influence significantly shapes spending behavior. Students who dine out frequently or buy trendy items create social pressure on their friends to follow suit, even if they can't afford it. The fear of being left out drives many to spend beyond their means.

Suggestions

Based on our findings, we offer the following suggestions, especially for freshmen who are managing money for the first time:

1. Make a monthly budget. At the beginning of each month, divide your allowance into categories: food, transportation, study materials, and entertainment. Stick to the plan and review it at the end of the month.

2. Track your spending. Use a budgeting app or simply keep a note on your phone. Knowing where your money goes is the first step to controlling it.

3. Build the habit of saving. Even 100 yuan a month adds up. Set up a separate account for savings and treat it as untouchable.

4. Be mindful of peer pressure. It's okay to say no when friends suggest expensive outings. Real friends will understand your situation.

5. Stay away from online lending. No matter how tempting it seems, online loans carry high interest rates and can trap you in a cycle of debt. If you need help, talk to your parents or school counselors first.

6. Take advantage of campus resources. Many universities offer free financial literacy workshops and counseling services. Don't hesitate to use them.

Conclusion

College is not just a time for academic growth—it is also the period when students learn to manage their lives independently, including their finances. Our survey shows that while many students struggle with spending habits, the problems are largely solvable through awareness, planning, and discipline. By developing healthy financial habits early, students can avoid unnecessary stress and focus on what truly matters: their education and personal growth.